

THE FOOL'S BALANCE

VOLUME 1

愚者は仮面を掲げ、
世界の均衡を見つめる。



The Fool's Balance

愚者の天秤

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Volume 1 – The Fool Who Challenged Heroes

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First digital edition 2026.

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Chapter 1 – The Fool Arrives

Sir Renji Arata had three reports.

Three different crimes.

Three different names.

A thief on the east road who stole nothing worth listing—only a merchant's certainty that the road was safe. A clown who walked into a wedding, clapped when the vows finished, and left before anyone decided whether to laugh or call the watch. A demon, according to a junior Hero's seal, written in the careful panic of someone who did not want to be wrong in public.

Demon activity. Unconfirmed. Requesting senior classification.

Same trail. Same direction. Same ridiculous little bell mentioned once in a margin, as if the writer had been embarrassed to ink it.

Renji hated impossible cases.

He folded the third report until the paper creased like a blade and tucked it into his belt. Classification was the Empire's favorite kindness. Name a thing, and the thing became a category. Categories could be hunted. Categories could be filed. Categories did not sit in the mud and smile at you while a village burned behind them.

Commander Hoshikawa's dispatch had been shorter than any of the reports.

Identify. Contain. Do not escalate without cause.

Renji rode alone. Silver armor caught the late light in disciplined flashes. His katana rested easy at his hip, Rei coiled under skin the way lightning waited in stormcloud—not eager, not sleeping. He had been a Hero long enough to know eagerness got people killed, and long enough to know sleep got them killed slower.

The road into Ashvale should have smelled of river mud and cooking smoke.

It smelled of wet ash and something sweet gone wrong.

Ashvale' s outer wall had been a joke even before today—stacked stone meant more for pride than for war. Pride lay in pieces across the lane. The gate hung half off its hinges like a tooth about to fall. Beyond it, roofs had collapsed inward. A well-house leaned as if listening for water that would never answer. Black scars crawled the timber where fire had eaten and then, somehow, stopped—not smothered by rain, not fought out by a bucket line. Stopped as if the fire itself had lost interest.

Renji dismounted at the break in the wall. His boots found glass. A child' s wooden horse lay on its side in the grit, one wheel still turning in the wind that had no business being this gentle.

He listened.

No screaming.

No clash of steel.

Only a thin sound—metal, small, ridiculous.

A bell.

Renji' s hand found his sword. Not drawn. Ready. Ready was different from drawn: ready still left room for the world to be ordinary.

He stepped through the ruined gate.

In the square, amid broken carts and the black ribs of a market stall, a man sat on an overturned crate as if the crate had been placed there for him.

White hair, messy, as if the wind had opinions and he had none. A long black coat patched in places that suggested repair by someone who did not care about matching thread. A faded red scarf. A cracked white theatrical mask hung from his belt; the crack ran from the left eye toward the mouth like a fault line deciding whether to finish the job. At his waist, a small silver bell chimed whenever he shifted his weight.

He was laughing.

Not the sharp laugh of victory. Not the broken laugh of shock. Something looser—delighted, almost private—as if the ruins had told him a joke and he was the only one who understood the punchline.

Renji' s first thought was madness.

His second was that madness did not usually wait for an audience.

“You,” Renji said. The word came out clean. Hero-clean. “Stand. Identify yourself.”

The laughing stopped as if cut with a knife. The man’s head tipped. Behind the empty space where a mask would have covered a face—no, the mask was on the belt; his face was bare—golden eyes found Renji with an ease that made Renji’s spine tighten. The smile remained. It looked like it had never left.

“Oh,” the man said. “You’re early.”

Renji waited.

The man looked around the destroyed village—slow, almost fond, as if admiring a stage after the actors had fled. Ash drifted past his shoulder. Somewhere a timber settled with a tired crack. His smile did not change.

“Good,” he said. “I was starting to get bored.”

Renji did not answer that. Early implied a schedule. Bored implied he had been waiting among corpses and ruin for entertainment. Intention, in a destroyed village, was a word that wanted blood.

“Name,” Renji said.

The man stood. The bell chimed, cheerful as a festival. He brushed ash from his coat with the seriousness of someone cleaning a table before dinner.

“People call me lots of things,” he said. “Thief. Clown. Demon. Once someone called me ‘sir,’ but I think they were dying, so it doesn’t count.”

Renji’s jaw set. “Your name.”

“Harlequin,” the man offered, as if lending Renji a cup. “Or Akihiko. Or The Fool, if you like your titles dramatic. I answer to the bell, mostly. It’s louder than I am.”

He flicked the silver bell with a fingertip. It sang once, bright and stupid in the ruin.

Renji stepped closer. Ash gritted under his boots. Close enough to measure distance. Close enough that lightning Rei could close the rest if the man moved wrong.

“This village was under Imperial protection,” Renji said. “Who did this?”

Akihiko–Renji refused The Fool even as his mind filed the title–tilted his head the other way.

“I don’ t know,” he said.

Renji’ s patience, trained for courts and battlefields alike, held. Barely. “You don’ t know.”

“No.” He looked faintly offended on behalf of honesty. “I wasn’ t there.”

“Then why are you here?”

“Because someone left the door open.”

“What door?”

Akihiko’ s smile widened a fraction–too pleased, too sharp for someone claiming ignorance.

“The one everyone agreed not to look for.”

A sound cut across the square–wood screaming, a roof giving up. Renji’ s head snapped toward the eastern lane. Smoke still threaded from a half–collapsed house. Under the groan of timber, a child’ s voice rose thin as wire.

“Mama–!”

Renji moved.

Lightning Rei woke along his legs, Shiki sharpening muscle and tendon into something that made distance negotiable. He crossed the square in a blur of silver and blue spark, boots finding purchase on broken stone. The house’ s front beam was failing. Inside, through the smoke–hole of a doorframe, he saw them: a woman pinned under a fallen joist, a boy no older than seven clawing at the wood with hands too small for the work, and behind them a secondary collapse starting–ceiling boards peeling like scabs.

Renji’ s blade cleared its sheath. He could cut the joist. Cutting the joist might drop the rest. He could brace. Bracing meant time he might not have. He chose the third option Heroes were taught when the world refused clean math: get the living out and let the building finish dying alone.

He reached the threshold–

—and nearly collided with white hair and a patched coat.

Akihiko was inside the doorway.

Renji's gut seized before his mind caught up—cold, animal, wrong. No human should have been able to move from the square to that doorway without making a sound. The bell had been silent. The ash had not whispered. Renji had been watching the beam. He told himself that was why. He had not been watching the man. That was the only explanation that did not require inventing a new kind of Rei—and Renji refused to invent things under fire.

Still, for one shameful heartbeat, his grip on the sword had tightened like a man facing something that should not exist.

“Borrowing,” Akihiko said cheerfully to no one, and kicked the support beam—not the joist pinning the woman, but a scorched upright two paces left that looked, to Renji's eye, like the only thing still doing its job.

The beam cracked.

Renji's shout died unfinished.

The roof did not fall on them.

It fell away—weight shifting, collapse rerouted, the house shedding itself into the alley like a beast rolling to expose a softer side. The joist lifted enough for Akihiko to slide an arm under the woman and haul. He moved wrong. He moved like a drunk stealing furniture. He moved like someone who had never studied structure.

The woman came free. The boy scrambled. Dust exploded. Renji caught the boy as the doorway coughed them into daylight, and for half a breath Renji's world was only small ribs under his gauntlet and the smell of ash in a child's hair.

Then the house finished dying behind them with a roar that would have been a funeral if anyone had been left to speak it.

Akihiko set the woman down against a trough that still held a finger of dirty water. He patted her shoulder once, gentle, absurd, as if she had coughed at a dinner table.

“There,” he said. “See? Kicking things works. People should kick more things. Politely.”

The woman stared at him. Tears cut clean lines through the soot on her face. The boy clung to Renji's armor and would not look up.

Renji's Rei still crackled under his skin, unused on the cut he had planned. His sword hung in his hand like an argument without a sentence.

"You nearly killed them," Renji said.

Akihiko blinked. "Did I? I was aiming for the other one. The dead one. The one pretending."

"That beam was holding—"

"No," he said, suddenly flat, as if correcting a child who had miscounted apples. Then the brightness snapped back. "Sorry. I get cranky when wood lies."

Renji looked back at the ruin. The alley collapse had missed a second house by a man's width. Missed a water barrel that, if crushed, would have flooded the lane into a slurry and trapped the next survivors crawling from a cellar door Renji had not even seen until now—three faces, pale, coughing, blinking at daylight as if daylight were a rumor.

Lucky.

Or not lucky.

Renji's training offered a colder word: precise.

He did not like that word in Akihiko's mouth. He did not like it in Akihiko's hands.

"Stay with them," Renji told the woman, and meant the boy too. "Do not run the main road. Wait for Imperial retrieval."

She nodded because Heroes said things that became instructions, and instructions were easier than hope.

Renji turned on him.

"You will explain what happened here."

"Will I?" Akihiko asked, interested, as if Renji had proposed a game.

Renji leveled his blade. Lightning crawled the steel in thin blue threads—not a Domain, not yet, only promise. "By Imperial authority of Akatsuki, under Hero command, you are detained for questioning regarding the

destruction of Ashvale and the endangerment of its people.”

He looked at the sword the way some men looked at weather.

“That’ s a very long sentence,” he said. “Do you charge by the word?”

“Surrender your Rei and kneel.”

“Ah.” He brightened. “Rules.”

He stepped sideways—not away, around, as if Renji’ s stance had a door Renji had forgotten to lock. Renji adjusted. Steel followed. Akihiko raised both empty hands.

“I don’ t have a weapon,” he said. “Does that make this unfair, or more fair? I can never remember which one Heroes prefer.”

“Last warning.”

“You already used one,” he said. “That was it. Do I get a receipt?”

Renji moved.

He did not waste motion. Shiki drove his first cut along a line that would stop at the coat, not the throat—Hero doctrine: disable, then question. Lightning Rei sharpened the edge’ s intent; the air cracked with the nearness of it.

Akihiko fell.

Not struck—or maybe struck by nothing but his own feet. Heels slipping on ash, body folding into a sprawl so complete it looked accidental. Renji’ s blade passed through empty air. Follow-through carried him a half-step past. Bad footing. Bad timing. Renji’ s, or his. Renji checked, pivoted, cut again for the wrist that would bind—

—and found his own sheath swinging up into his path. Akihiko had rolled through the fall into a sit with Renji’ s empty sheath in both hands. When had he taken it? During the slip. During the laugh. During the half-second Renji’ s eyes had tracked steel instead of fingers.

Wood met steel with a stupid, solid clack.

Renji’ s eyes widened a fraction. He twisted, freed the blade, kicked for the sheath—

Akihiko let go.

The sheath clattered. Renji's kick hit nothing—or hit the place he had been a blink ago, which was the same as nothing. For one exposed heartbeat Renji's weight was committed wrong, and a finger—just a finger—tapped the flat of Renji's katana as if testing a pot for heat.

“Hot,” he observed. “You care a lot.”

Renji's next strike came harder. Pride was a sin. Leaving an opening was worse. Lightning flared. The cut would have split a training post and the post behind it.

Akihiko stepped into Renji's guard.

Closer—not faster than Renji could swear to. Into the space where a long blade became an awkward stick, where Renji's perfect distance collapsed into elbows and breath. His forehead nearly bumped Renji's chin. Golden eyes filled Renji's vision, amused.

“Ow,” he said, though nothing had touched him. “You're very stabby for someone who wants answers.”

Renji drove a gauntleted fist toward his ribs—close-range, Shiki-backed, honest.

Akihiko laughed.

Renji's fist met coat—or ash—or the idea of a man. No blur. No afterimage he could name. Only the sick certainty that either he had missed a target at arm's length, or the target had never intended to be where Renji's eyes said he was. Renji's own momentum turned him toward the trough where the rescued woman still sat. He stopped the strike before it became a crime against the innocent. The stop cost him a grunt. Cost him balance. Cost him the clean story of the exchange.

Later, if anyone asked, he would not know which account to give.

When he turned again, Akihiko stood five paces off, holding Renji's dropped sheath like a conductor's baton. He offered it forward with both hands, ceremonial and absurd.

“You dropped this,” he said. “Heroes should keep their things. The world is full of thieves.”

Renji took the sheath. His fingers brushed Akihiko's. Warm. Human. No

demonic cold. No holy burn. Just skin and ash.

That, somehow, was worse.

“What are you?” Renji asked.

Akihiko’s smile tilted. “Hungry, mostly. Also handsome. The second one’s disputed.”

He dug in his coat and held up an empty paper wrapper between two fingers, solemn as a priest presenting evidence. There was nothing left inside but crumbs and a smear of something sticky.

“I only packed one snack,” he said. “You arrived before I could steal another. Rude.”

“Why save them?”

“The boy was loud,” he said, as if that settled law. “Loud children are hard to ignore. Like bells.” He flicked his own. “Also, roofs that want to quit are rude. I hate rude architecture.”

“And the village?” Renji’s voice tightened. “Who attacked Ashvale?”

Akihiko’s gaze drifted—not to Renji, not to the survivors, but to the leaning gate and the road beyond, where evening had begun to bruise the sky.

“Dunno,” he said. “Someone with bad manners. Or good manners and a worse hobby. People get weird about doors.”

“Speak plainly.”

“I am speaking plainly,” Akihiko said. “You’re just listening in Hero.”

Renji sheathed his sword. The click of steel home sounded like a decision he had not finished making. Containment required a living subject. Escalation without cause violated Hoshikawa’s line. Cause stood all around them in charcoal and silence, and still Renji could not point to this man’s hand and say there.

“You call yourself The Fool,” Renji said.

“Because everyone else already decided what everyone was supposed to be,” Akihiko replied, light as gossip. Then, brighter, as if remembering a joke: “Hero. Villain. Victim. Homework.”

“And you?”

“I hate assignments.” He wrinkled his nose. “Especially the ones written in blood. Terrible handwriting. Very dramatic. Nobody thinks about the cleanup.”

Renji stared at him. “You will come with me to the capital. Willingly, or bound.”

“Bound is a strong look on some people,” Akihiko said. “On me it just looks like fashion. Also itchy.”

He walked past Renji.

Not fleeing. Not charging. Walking toward the ruined gate as if the conversation had reached its natural end and politeness required him to leave the table. The bell chimed with each step. Renji’s hand returned to his hilt.

“Stop.”

Akihiko stopped under the leaning gate-arch. He put a palm to the scarred wood. For a moment he looked almost solemn—almost like a man touching a grave.

Then: “Ah.”

He looked at the gate the way a cook looks at a pot left on the fire too long.

“Still closed.”

Renji’s brow furrowed. “What?”

“That’s rude,” Akihiko said.

Rei moved.

Renji felt it—not lightning, not any discipline he could file under Shiki or Kotodama or Kage. It felt like a joke told in a language he almost recognized.

The gate did not shatter.

For one impossible heartbeat, Renji had the absurd thought that the gate was embarrassed—caught still pretending to be closed after the village behind it had already failed. Timber blushed with dust. Hinges forgot their argument. The arch did not explode outward in a warrior’s blast; it simply stopped belonging to the idea of a barrier, and the world, polite as a bad host, accepted the correction.

Wood and stone settled into the lane as if they had always been rubble

there. No clean break-lines. No heroic crater. Only an opening that looked older than the wall, as if Ashvale had never bothered with a gate at all.

Survivors cried out anyway—not from flying spars, but from the wrongness of a landmark vanishing while their eyes were open. Renji's Rei flared on instinct and found nothing to catch. His blue veil closed on empty air.

When the dust thinned, the entrance to Ashvale was a wound with no lips. The road lay open. Nothing stood between the ruin and the Empire's horizon.

Akihiko stood in the middle of what had been an arch, coat gray with powder, smiling as if he had opened a window in a stuffy room.

Renji's voice came out low. "Why?"

He looked at the place where the gate had been—and could not, for a moment, remember how high the hinges had hung.

A criminal had done this.

A monster had saved the survivors.

A madman had noticed what every soldier would have missed—the beam that was already dead, the cellar mouths, the quiet that mattered more than the fire.

And the worst part was that Renji could not decide which description was wrong.

Akihiko turned.

For the first time since Renji had entered the square, the laughter was gone from everything except the eyes.

"You're a hero, right?" The Fool asked.

Renji did not lower his guard. Ash still drifted between them like slow snow. Behind him, a village that had been a place was becoming a report. Ahead of him, Akihiko waited as if the answer mattered more than the sword—as if he had been waiting for a Hero specifically, and Renji's arrival was not coincidence but confirmation.

"I am Sir Renji Arata," Renji said. "Hero of Akatsuki."

Akihiko's smile returned—smaller, sharper, almost relieved.

"Good," he said.

He stepped through the open road, close enough that Renji could have ended him in one honest cut, and did not look at the blade at all.

“I was worried nobody would come.”

Chapter 2 – The Man Who Lost the Fight Before It Began

Sir Renji Arata did not let him take a second step.

Steel cleared the sheath with a clean ring that belonged to parade grounds and court oaths, not ruined villages. Lightning Rei woke along the blade in thin blue threads. Between Renji and the open road stood the end of Hoshikawa's patience—and the beginning of Renji's.

"Harlequin Akihiko," Renji said. "By Hero authority of Akatsuki, you will halt and submit to binding. If you refuse, I will treat this as armed resistance."

Behind him, Ashvale still breathed wrong. Survivors huddled near the trough—the woman, the boy, the pale faces from the cellar. Smoke thinned into evening. Where the gate had been, the wall simply... opened, as if the village had never owned a hinge. Renji did not look at that wound for long. Looking made his memory slip, and Heroes did not afford slips with witnesses watching.

Akihiko stopped because Renji's sword asked him to, not because the words did.

He turned. The cracked mask hung from his belt. The silver bell chimed once, cheerful as a festival no one had invited.

For a moment he said nothing. He only looked at Renji the way a bored audience looks at an actor who has forgotten his entrance.

Then, mildly: "You're still doing the Hero speech."

"This is not a speech," Renji said. "It is law."

"Ah." Akihiko nodded, solemn. "Law. Very heavy. Do you carry it in your pockets, or does it follow you around like a dog?"

Renji's jaw tightened. "Draw a weapon, or kneel."

"I don't have a weapon," Akihiko said. He lifted empty hands, then patted his coat as if checking for spare cutlery. "Unless you count the snack

wrapper. It's sharp if you fold it wrong. Very advanced technique. I invented it yesterday."

"Then kneel."

Akihiko considered the ash at his feet. Considered Renji's blade. Considered the survivors with a glance so brief it almost looked careless—and landed, somehow, exactly on the boy's scraped knuckles.

"No," he said.

Renji stepped in. Distance closed to the length of a proper duel. "You refuse containment."

"I refuse homework," Akihiko said. "Kneeling is homework. Fighting you is also homework. I'm on break."

"This is not a game."

"You're the one who brought rules," Akihiko replied, brightening. "I brought a bell. We're mismatched."

Renji felt the old instinct rise—the same cold seize that had betrayed him in the burning doorway. He crushed it under discipline until only heat remained. Heat he could use.

"Then I challenge you," Renji said. Formal. Clean. The words Heroes used when a criminal's smile outran ordinary arrest. "Stand and face me. No tricks. No bystanders harmed. Yield when you are beaten."

Ash drifted between them.

Akihiko's smile did not arrive at once. That was worse. For two heartbeats his face was only golden eyes and the ruin reflected in them, and Renji understood—without understanding why—that something in this man found the challenge less funny than the world expected.

Then the smile came back, small and wrong.

"I don't want to fight you," Akihiko said.

"You don't get to want."

"Rude." Akihiko rocked on his heels. "Also inaccurate. Wanting is free. Like air. Or bad decisions."

"Last chance."

“You keep saying that,” Akihiko said. “Do Heroes buy warnings in bulk? Is there a discount?”

Renji moved.

The first cut was doctrine: disable the shoulder, end the joke, bind the wrists. Shiki drove his legs. Lightning sharpened the edge’s intent. The air cracked.

Akihiko leaned—not away, aside, as if Renji had announced the angle in writing. The blade kissed coat-thread and nothing else. Renji flowed into the second line without pride or pause: wrist, then knee, then the flat of the blade toward the collarbone—

Akihiko’s boot caught a loose roof tile. He stumbled, arms windmilling, and fell into Renji’s third cut so completely that Renji had to abort mid-strike or take the man’s throat by accident.

The abort cost balance. Cost breath. Cost the clean story of the exchange.

Akihiko sat in the ash, blinked twice, and held up a finger.

“See?” he said. “I told you. Homework. I failed already. Very educational.”

“Get up.”

“Are you sure? Sitting is safer. For both of us. Mostly for your dignity.”

Renji’s blade hovered. From the trough, the boy made a small sound. Renji did not turn. Turning would make the child a hostage to his attention. He kept his eyes on Akihiko and raised his free hand once—stay—Hero sign language for civilians who had already learned that obedience was cheaper than hope.

Akihiko saw the gesture. Of course he did. He waved at the boy with two fingers, cheerful as a festival uncle.

“Hi,” he called. “Don’t copy him. He has a sword. You have... ash. Ash is worse. Trust me.”

“Stop speaking to them,” Renji said.

“They’re part of the scenery,” Akihiko said. Then, softer, almost offended: “No. They’re people. Scenery is rude.”

He stood. Dusted his coat. The bell chimed.

Renji attacked again.

This time he varied the pattern—high feint into low sweep, lightning cracking a false line while his body committed to the true one. Academy instructors called it breaking habit. Renji had broken other men's habits with it for years.

Akihiko stepped into the false line.

Not the true one. The false one—the one Renji had offered as bait. Their shoulders nearly collided. Renji's true cut swung through empty evening. Akihiko's forehead nearly bumped his chin again, close enough that Renji smelled ash and sugar on his breath.

"You're very consistent," Akihiko said, as if complimenting a soup. "It's cute. Like a clock. Clocks are honest. Clocks also get smashed when people hate mornings."

Renji shoved him back with a gauntleted palm. Akihiko stumbled—or performed stumbling—and laughed when he caught himself on a broken cart.

"I am not here to amuse you," Renji said.

"Then stop being amusing."

Renji's next sequence was faster. Shiki burned clean through muscle. Sparks leapt from steel. He drove Akihiko toward the open road, away from the trough, away from soft bodies and soft mistakes. That was the second storyline pulling at him even as the first demanded bloodless victory: protect the living, then bind the impossible. Hoshikawa would want a report. The capital would want a classification. Ashvale would become a file with a number, and Renji already hated the number he could not yet write.

Akihiko let himself be herded.

That should have felt like winning.

It felt like being allowed.

He tripped on nothing Renji could see, rolled under a horizontal cut, came up with a stick, and offered it forward like a second sword.

"There," Akihiko said. "Now it's fair. I have a weapon. It's a stick. Very prestigious. From the House of Stick."

Renji cut the stick in half.

Both halves fell. Akihiko looked devastated for one theatrical second, then brightened.

“Oh good. Now I have two. Dual wield.”

He threw one half at Renji’s face.

Renji slanted his head. The wood passed. In that half-breath of correction—the exact habit Renji used when debris came high—Akihiko stepped through the space Renji’s blade had left behind and tapped Renji’s breastplate with the other half, gentle as knocking on a door.

Tok.

“Hello,” Akihiko said. “Anybody home?”

Renji’s gut seized—not fear of death. Fear of pattern. The same wrongness as the silent doorway. No human should read a Hero’s correction that cleanly on a first meeting. Unless it was luck. Unless Renji had telegraphed. Unless—

He refused the list. Lists were for reports. Reports came after.

He slammed a knee forward. Akihiko folded around it like laundry and sat down hard, eyes watering.

“Ow,” he said, sincere this time. “Okay. That one counted. You’re improving.”

“Yield.”

“No.” Akihiko wiped his eyes with a filthy sleeve. “Also, you’re telegraphing the knee. Left hip dips. Tiny. Like a shy dancer. Very charming. Stop it.”

Renji froze for a fraction of a second he would deny later.

His left hip did dip. An old instructor had flagged it once, years ago. Renji had sanded the habit down until even sparring partners missed it.

Akihiko said it like weather.

Renji stopped trying to take him cleanly.

Lightning flared harder. The square flashed blue-white. He cut for the

legs—bind by force, not courtesy. Akihiko hopped—ridiculous, knees high, bell screaming—and the cut chewed ash. Renji reversed, pommel toward temple—

Akihiko's hand was somehow already under the pommel, guiding it past his ear as if helping Renji miss politely.

"Careful," Akihiko said. "You almost hit me. That would be awkward for your report. 'Subject bruised. Hero embarrassed. Stick deceased.' "

"Be silent."

"Make me."

Renji did not take the bait into rage. Rage was a civilian luxury. He took it into precision.

Three exchanges. Five. Eight. Every clean line Renji owned became a conversation Akihiko had already finished. Not faster—Renji could swear that much. Not stronger. Just... early. As if Renji's choices arrived a breath after Akihiko had already filed them.

Or as if Renji was simply predictable, and the ash was laughing with him.

From the trough, the woman whispered a prayer. The boy watched Renji the way children watched storms: wanting the lightning to be beautiful and afraid of what it hit.

Renji angled another sequence to keep their bodies out of his wake. The choice cost him a tempo. Akihiko did not punish the opening with a strike. He used it to stroll two steps closer to the open road, hands in his pockets, as if the duel were a walk he had agreed to accompany.

"You're protecting them," Akihiko said, almost kindly. "Good. Heroes should. It's in the brochure."

"You will not use them."

"I wasn't going to." Akihiko looked faintly offended again. "I'm annoying, not boring."

Renji's Rei climbed toward a threshold he had sworn not to cross here.

Domain.

Absolute Duel.

Inside it, the world narrowed to one opponent. No crowd. No trough. No boy.

No Ashvale. Only the fight Renji understood—rules so pure they became a cage for anything that refused to be classified.

Hoshikawa's line flickered in his mind: Do not escalate without cause.

Cause stood in front of him wearing a smile and a bell.

Cause also sat behind him with scraped knuckles.

If Renji opened Absolute Duel in a ruin full of survivors, he did not know what the Domain would do to the soft edges of the village—whether it would erase them from the fight, or erase them from mattering. He had never tested it around civilians. Heroes who tested Domains around civilians became cautionary stories with blacked-out names.

Renji's grip whitened on the hilt.

Lightning crawled to his elbow, hungry for the shape of a world with only one enemy.

Akihiko watched the light gather. His eyes tracked Renji's Rei the way a cook tracks a pot about to boil over—interested, not afraid.

"Oh," Akihiko said. "You're thinking about the big shiny thing. Cheating. Same hobby, different hat."

Renji's breath caught.

"I'm thinking about ending this."

"Ending is dramatic," Akihiko began, cheerful, already reaching for the next joke—

Then he stopped.

"Oh, wait. The children."

He glanced past Renji's shoulder, toward the trough, as if he had only just remembered the village contained people who were not scenery.

"That would be awkward," he said. "Imagine explaining to them that the Hero saved everyone except the people standing five meters away. Very bad brochure. One star. Would not recommend."

The wisdom arrived late, tangled in nonsense—but it landed on the truth Renji was already holding.

Renji hated that.

He hated more that Akihiko seemed surprised by his own glance, as if the insight had tripped over him rather than been aimed.

Slowly—discipline over pride—Renji throttled the Domain back down. Lightning sank into the blade alone. The air stopped trembling toward a private universe.

For the first time since Renji had entered Ashvale, Akihiko's smile arrived late.

He had expected a prideful Hero. A predictable swordsman. Someone who would choose the clean win and let the world tidy itself afterward.

He had not expected this: Renji's jaw locked, eyes clear, Domain dying by choice while the insult of cheating still hung in the air unanswered.

"...Huh," Akihiko said, quieter. Then, recovering with both hands waving: "Good—no. Not good boy. Sorry. Dog thing. You're not a dog. Dogs sit faster. You're... a very stabby librarian."

Renji did not smile. Did not flinch. Did not give the joke the courtesy of disgust. His eyes stayed on Akihiko's hands, his weight, the open road—work, not theater.

Akihiko's smile, when it finally finished arriving, was thinner at the edges.

"You know," he said, almost curious, "most people laugh by now. Or shout. Or try to impress me with the shiny thing anyway. Pride is loud."

"Most people are easier to distract," Renji said.

Akihiko looked genuinely surprised—as if he had reached for a door marked Hero and found discipline bolted from the inside.

"Rude," he said. "Accurate. Worst combination."

Renji exhaled through his teeth and attacked anyway—not with Domain, with everything else he was allowed to be.

The last sequence was the best Renji had thrown since the Academy finals.

No wasted motion. No hip dip. Feints that weren't bait so much as

weather—pressure from every angle until a man’ s choices collapsed into one. Lightning Rei stitched the cuts together into a single argument: you are contained.

Akihiko walked through it.

Not danced. Not blurred. Walked—shoulders loose, bell ticking, as if Renji’ s masterpiece were a crowded market and Akihiko knew which stalls to avoid without looking at the signs. Renji’ s final thrust stopped a finger’ s width from Akihiko’ s heart because Akihiko had turned a half-degree and Renji refused to skewer a man who was no longer on the line.

They stood locked in that almost.

Ash fell between the blade and the coat.

Renji’ s arms shook—not from fatigue. From the sick certainty that he had not been fighting a fleeing criminal.

He had been performing.

“You...” Renji’ s voice came out low. “You know me.”

Not the future. Not prophecy. Something worse—closer. The hip. The Domain. The way Renji protected the trough before he protected his pride. As if Akihiko had been reading a man, not a moment.

Akihiko blinked. “Do I? What’ s your favorite color? Wait—don’ t tell me. It’ s ‘responsibility.’ Very fashionable this season.”

“The feint,” Renji said. “The knee. When I almost—” He cut the word Domain off like a confession. “That is not luck alone.”

“Oh. That.” Akihiko scratched his cheek with one finger, leaving a soot comma. “I don’ t know. Maybe. Or you talk with your shoulders. Or I’ m lucky. Or you’ re very organized, and organized people are easy to read, like menus. Or—” He brightened. “—I made it all up and you’ re complimenting me by accident. That happens. I’ m magnetic.”

Renji did not lower the sword. He could not. Lowering it would admit the shape of the loss.

“You were never avoiding me,” Renji said.

Akihiko’ s eyes flicked—quick, pleased, almost shy—as if Renji had finally said a useful sentence.

“No,” Akihiko said. Then, lighter, undercutting himself before the word could become philosophy: “Avoiding is cardio. I hate cardio. I was just... taking notes. Mentally. On invisible paper. Very eco-friendly.”

Studying him.

Not like an opponent hunting weakness.

Like someone checking whether a door was actually locked.

Renji’s stomach turned. The survivors’ whispers sounded suddenly far away. The open road looked like a mouth. Somewhere in the capital, Hoshikawa would open a report that began with Identify and ended with a word Renji did not yet have permission to write.

“Why?” Renji asked.

Akihiko stepped back from the point of the blade as if from a flower with thorns. He glanced once at the place where the gate had been—Renji’s memory stuttered on hinge height again, a toothache in the mind—and then smiled his ordinary, unbearable smile.

“Because you’re a hero,” Akihiko said. “And I was worried nobody would come.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It’s a start.” Akihiko pointed past Renji, toward the trough, toward the ruined square, toward the evening swallowing Ashvale. “Also, your people need water that isn’t gossip, and your Commander needs a story that isn’t ‘I swung a lot and felt sad.’ You should write that I tripped. It’s true. Emotionally.”

“You will come to the capital,” Renji said. It came out less like an order than a vow scraped raw. “Willingly or bound. I will not leave Ashvale as another rumor with a bell.”

Akihiko’s gaze went distant for half a breath—listening to something Renji could not hear, or pretending to.

“Capital,” he repeated. “Big walls. Bigger assignments. Fun.”

He turned toward the open road as if the duel had been a door he had finished examining.

Renji’s sword rose. “I did not dismiss you.”

“I know.” Akihiko looked back over his shoulder. Golden eyes; cracked mask on the belt; bell quiet for once. “That’s why this next part matters.”

“What next part?”

Akihiko’s smile tilted—idiot first, knife second.

“The part where you decide whether you’re chasing me...”

He paused, as if tasting the next word for salt.

“...or following.”

He flicked the silver bell.

It sang once across the ruin, bright and stupid and impossible to classify.

Then he stepped onto the road—not running, not surrendering—and did not look back to see if Renji would follow.

Renji stood in Ashvale’s wound with lightning dying on his blade and the taste of a fight he had lost before the first cut.

The road ahead was open.

Akihiko had not fled.

He had not surrendered.

And for the first time since entering Ashvale, Renji understood the thing that disturbed him most.

Akihiko had not been waiting for a Hero.

He had been waiting for Renji.

End of Book One

The Fool's Balance – 愚者の天秤